COMPLETE ACADEMY WORKBOOK

The Shadow Work Academy

From self-doubt to self-trust.

Six modules · Lessons · Scenarios · Reflections · Worksheets · Action steps

Version 1.0

Quick-Start Guide

How the academy works, a suggested two-to-six week pace, and how to look after yourself while you do the work.

Welcome

The Shadow Work Academy is a structured, self-paced program of six modules. Each one has a lesson, a scenario, reflection questions, a worksheet, a real-world action, and a recap. It is a self-reflection tool, not therapy or medical advice.

How to move through it

- Plan on 45–60 minutes per module for the lesson and worksheet, plus a week of practice for the action step.
- A comfortable pace is one module per week (six weeks). Two weeks per module is also fine.
- Do the modules in order; each one builds on the last.
- Answer in your own words. Short, honest answers are better than polished ones.
- You can skip any prompt that feels like too much right now.

Using the interactive academy

- Open START-HERE.html from your download folder and choose Open the Academy, in a modern browser: Chrome, Safari, Firefox or Edge.
- Your answers are saved in your browser on this device. Nothing is sent anywhere by the academy itself.
- Because answers live in that one browser, use the Backup button on the Progress page regularly to save a file copy. Clearing browser data will erase unsaved answers.
- Use the Print button on any module to get a clean worksheet, or use the PDF workbook if you prefer paper.

Taking care of yourself

Stop whenever you need to. If you feel overwhelmed, take a break, talk to someone you trust, or contact a licensed mental health professional. If you may be in danger or thinking about harming yourself, contact local emergency services or a crisis line in your country right away.

MODULE 1 OF 6 · ABOUT 45 MINUTES

Meet Your Shadow

Learn to read your own patterns before you try to change them.

Lesson

What “shadow work” actually means here

“Shadow” is a term popularized by the psychiatrist Carl Jung. In everyday use it describes the parts of ourselves we have learned to hide, push down, or not look at: needs we were told were too much, feelings that felt unwelcome, qualities we judged in ourselves or in other people.

In this academy we use the word in a practical, grounded way. Shadow work simply means getting curious about the patterns you run on autopilot: the reactions that surprise you, the situations that keep repeating, the moments where you act against what you know is good for you. You are not digging for hidden monsters. You are learning to notice what is already there, name it accurately, and decide what to do with it.

This is self-reflection, not therapy. It cannot diagnose anything or replace care from a qualified professional, and you should feel free to stop, slow down, or seek support at any point.

Why patterns matter more than single moments

One awkward conversation tells you very little. The same awkward conversation happening for the fourth time with different people tells you a lot. Patterns are where self-understanding becomes useful, because a pattern points to a need, a belief, or a habit that is doing quiet work in the background.

A pattern usually has four parts, and learning to separate them is the single most useful skill in this module:

- Trigger — the situation or signal that sets things off (a delayed reply, a raised tone, being asked for a favor).
- Automatic reaction — what you feel and do before you have time to decide (your stomach drops, you apologize, you say yes).
- Story — the meaning you attach, often instantly (“I’ve upset them,” “I’m failing,” “they don’t respect me”).

- Payoff and cost — what the reaction protects you from in the short term, and what it costs you over time.

Every pattern had a reason

Most automatic reactions began as sensible solutions. A child who learned that keeping the peace kept the house calm becomes an adult who agrees too quickly. A student who was only praised for results becomes someone who cannot rest without producing. The reaction worked once, so it got repeated until it stopped feeling like a choice.

This matters because it changes the tone of the work. If a pattern once helped you, then judging yourself for it is inaccurate as well as unkind. The more useful question is: “What is this pattern trying to protect, and is it still the best way to do that?”

How to tell a trigger from a cause

A trigger is not the same as the reason you react. Your coworker’s short email is the trigger; the reason it hurts may be an older belief that you are only valued when you are useful. Triggers are easy to spot because they are external. Causes take a little patience, because they sit underneath.

A reliable clue is proportion. When your reaction is noticeably larger or longer-lasting than the event seems to warrant, something beneath the surface has been touched. That is not evidence that you are overreacting in a bad way. It is a signpost telling you where to look.

How to do this work safely

Work at a pace that leaves you steady. If a prompt stirs up something heavy, you are allowed to skip it, shorten your answer, or come back another day. Choose a time and place where you will not be interrupted, and finish each session with something grounding: a glass of water, a short walk, a message to a friend.

If you are experiencing persistent distress, thoughts of harming yourself, or you are dealing with trauma or abuse, please contact a licensed mental health professional or local emergency services. This program is a self-guided educational tool and is not a substitute for professional care.

Scenario: The unanswered message

Maya sends a long, careful message to a friend about weekend plans. Three hours pass with no reply. By the evening she has re-read her message several times, decided she sounded needy, and drafted two apologies she has not sent. Her stomach feels tight and she cannot concentrate on dinner.

Here is Maya's pattern, separated into parts. Trigger: silence after sending a message. Automatic reaction: tight stomach, re-reading, drafting apologies. Story: "I said too much and now they're annoyed with me." Payoff: preparing an apology feels like control over a situation she cannot control. Cost: an evening of anxiety and a habit of over-apologizing for things that did not need an apology.

Notice that Maya did nothing wrong. The pattern is not her flaw; it is a learned way of managing uncertainty. Once she can see the four parts, she has a gap between the trigger and her reaction, and a gap is where choice lives.

Guided reflection

Take your time. Short, honest answers are enough. Skip anything that feels like too much today.

1. Think of a recent moment when your reaction felt bigger than the situation. What happened, and what did you feel in your body first?

2. What story did your mind attach to that moment? Write it in the exact words it used, even if the words feel harsh.

3. Where have you seen a very similar reaction before — a different person or place, but the same feeling?

4. If this reaction once helped you, what was it protecting you from? Who or what taught you it was necessary?

5. What does this pattern cost you now, in energy, relationships, or choices?

Worksheet

Worksheet: Pattern Map

Choose three recent situations that left you tense, defensive, or drained. Fill in one row for each. Aim for specific facts, not summaries. “My boss changed the deadline in a meeting” is better than “work stress.”

Completed example (fictional): Maya's Pattern Map

TRIGGER

A friend hadn't replied to a long message after three hours.

AUTOMATIC REACTION

Tight stomach. Re-read my message four times. Drafted two apologies I didn't send.

STORY I TOLD MYSELF

"I said too much and now they're annoyed with me."

WHAT IT PROTECTED / WHAT IT COST

Protected: preparing an apology felt like control. Cost: an anxious evening and a habit of over-apologizing.

WHAT THE ROWS HAVE IN COMMON

When I can't tell what someone thinks of me, I try to fix it before I know there is a problem.

NAME FOR THE PATTERN

"The Apology Draft"

Fictional example for illustration. Your own answers can be shorter, messier, and entirely different.

Trigger (what happened)	Automatic reaction (feeling + action)	Story I told myself	What it protected / what it cost

Looking across your three rows, what do they have in common?

Give this pattern a short, neutral name (for example “The Apology Draft” or “Quiet Scorekeeping”).

Real-world action: The three-second notice

For the next seven days, catch one automatic reaction per day. You are not trying to stop it. At the moment it happens, silently name the trigger and the story (“Trigger: silence. Story: I annoyed them.”). Afterwards, jot it into the Trigger & Pattern Tracker in your resource library. The goal is observation only.

What I did, what happened, what I noticed:

Module recap

- Shadow work here means getting curious about your automatic patterns, not hunting for something wrong with you.
- A pattern has four parts: trigger, automatic reaction, story, and payoff/cost.
- Most patterns began as reasonable solutions, so self-judgment is both inaccurate and unhelpful.
- A reaction that feels bigger than the event is a signpost pointing to something underneath.
- Go at a steady pace and seek professional support when you need it.

Completion record

My key insight from this module:

Date completed: ___ / ___ / _____

MODULE 2 OF 6 · ABOUT 50 MINUTES

Rebuild Self-Worth

Move your sense of worth off other people’s reactions and onto something steadier.

Lesson

Conditional versus steady self-worth

Many people carry an unspoken rule about when they are allowed to feel good about themselves: “I’m fine if I’m productive,” “I’m fine if people are pleased with me,” “I’m fine if I don’t make mistakes.” This is conditional self-worth. It works well while the conditions are met and collapses the moment they are not.

Steady self-worth is a quieter idea. It does not require you to be impressive, agreeable, or flawless. It is the baseline belief that you are a person whose needs and feelings matter, even on days you fall short of your own standards. It is not arrogance and it does not remove ambition; it simply stops every outcome from becoming a verdict on you.

How external validation becomes a habit

Praise, approval, and being needed feel good, and there is nothing wrong with enjoying them. The trouble starts when they become the main way you check whether you are okay. Each time you look outward for reassurance, you practice not trusting your own read of the situation.

Common signs of leaning on external validation include rehearsing how a message will be received before you send it, feeling a dip in mood when a post or an effort goes unnoticed, changing your opinion mid-conversation after a flicker of disagreement, and finding it hard to enjoy an achievement until someone confirms it was good.

Comparison as a self-worth meter

Comparison is often a symptom of conditional worth. If your value depends on performance, then other people’s performance becomes a measuring stick, and you are constantly reading where you

rank. Social media supplies an endless feed of other people's highlights, which makes the meter run all day.

A helpful reframe is to ask what the comparison is pointing at. Envy often reveals a value or a desire: you may admire someone's calm, creativity, or courage because you want more of it. Treated as information rather than a ranking, comparison can show you what matters to you.

Self-abandonment: leaving yourself to keep the peace

Self-abandonment is the habit of overriding your own needs, preferences, or judgment in order to stay accepted. It can look small: saying you're fine with the restaurant, laughing at a joke you didn't like, answering emails at midnight because you can't bear to disappoint someone.

Each instance may seem harmless. Over time, though, the message you send yourself is that your inner experience is optional. Rebuilding self-worth involves reversing that message in small, repeatable ways, starting with noticing what you actually want before deciding what to say.

Values: a more stable anchor

Because outcomes and opinions shift, they make an unreliable foundation. Values are different. A value is a direction you choose to live toward, such as honesty, kindness, curiosity, or craftsmanship. You can act in line with a value whether or not anyone notices and whether or not things go well.

That is why the exercise in this module centers on values. When you can say "I acted in line with what matters to me," you have a source of self-respect that does not depend on a reaction from someone else.

Scenario: The presentation that went fine

Daniel gives a presentation to his team. It goes well, nobody asks hard questions, and he leaves the room feeling relieved. Then a colleague mentions that another team's presentation "blew everyone away." Within minutes Daniel has replayed every pause in his talk and decided it was mediocre.

What shifted was not the presentation but the measuring stick. Before the comment, Daniel judged himself on whether he did what he set out to do. After it, he judged himself on rank. A values-based check would sound like this: "I wanted to be clear and prepared. I was. That's the part I control."

Daniel can still be curious about what made the other talk strong. The difference is that learning from it no longer requires him to decide he is lacking.

Guided reflection

Take your time. Short, honest answers are enough. Skip anything that feels like too much today.

1. Complete this sentence honestly: “I feel okay about myself when _____.” What does your answer reveal about your conditions?

2. Where in your life do you most often check other people’s reactions before trusting your own judgment?

3. Who do you compare yourself to most, and what quality in them are you actually drawn to?

4. Describe one recent moment you set aside what you wanted to keep things smooth. What would honoring yourself have looked like?

5. Think of someone you care about who is struggling with a mistake. What would you say to them, and how does it differ from what you say to yourself?

Worksheet

Worksheet: Self-Worth and Values Reflection

Part A explores the conditions you currently attach to your worth. Part B turns your values into concrete daily behavior.

Part A — Tick the conditions that sound familiar (tick as many as apply):

- [ ] I'm worthwhile when I'm productive.
- [ ] I'm worthwhile when people are pleased with me.
- [ ] I'm worthwhile when I look capable and in control.
- [ ] I'm worthwhile when I'm needed.
- [ ] I'm worthwhile when I don't make mistakes.
- [ ] I'm worthwhile when I'm doing better than others.

Which condition feels strongest, and where do you think you learned it?

Part B — Value 1 (e.g. honesty, kindness, growth, courage, curiosity, calm):

One small action this week that lives this value, regardless of how it is received:

Value 2:

One small action this week that lives this value:

Value 3:

One small action this week that lives this value:

Write a steady-worth statement in your own words, such as “My worth does not depend on _____. I can still _____ when I fall short.”

Real-world action: Check yourself first

Once a day this week, before asking anyone “Was that okay?” or checking a reaction, pause and write one sentence: “My own read is _____.” Then notice whether you still need the outside confirmation. Often you will find you already knew.

What I did, what happened, what I noticed:

Module recap

- Conditional self-worth rises and falls with performance and approval; steady self-worth does not.
- Looking outward for reassurance is a habit, and habits can be gradually reshaped.
- Comparison can be treated as information about what you value, not a ranking.
- Self-abandonment is quiet and repeated; reversing it also starts small.
- Values give you an anchor that does not depend on anyone’s reaction.

Completion record

My key insight from this module:

Date completed: ___ / ___ / _____

MODULE 3 OF 6 · ABOUT 50 MINUTES

Understand Your Inner Narrator

Tell the difference between what happened and what your mind says about it.

Lesson

The voice that narrates your life

Most of us carry a running commentary: evaluating how we spoke, what we wore, whether we are keeping up. This inner narrator is not a flaw. It is a normal feature of how minds work. The question is not whether it exists, but what it says and how much authority you give it.

For many people the narrator speaks in a tone they would never use with a friend: “You always do this,” “Why can’t you just be normal,” “Everyone can see you’re struggling.” Because the voice is familiar, it can feel like honesty. Often it is just habit wearing honesty’s clothes.

Recognizing harsh self-talk

Harsh self-talk tends to have recognizable features. Listen for absolutes (“always,” “never,” “everyone”), labels instead of descriptions (“I’m pathetic” rather than “I made an error in that report”), mind-reading (“They think I’m incompetent”), and predictions delivered as certainties (“This will go badly”).

You do not need to argue with every thought. Simply noticing the format is powerful, because a thought that sounds like “fact” starts to look more like “a sentence my mind produced.”

Limiting beliefs: old conclusions treated as facts

A limiting belief is a conclusion about yourself or the world that you reached at some point and then stopped questioning: “I’m not a natural leader,” “Asking for help makes me a burden,” “If I relax, things fall apart.” Such beliefs often form from a handful of real experiences, then expand to cover everything.

Beliefs are held in place by selective attention. Once you believe you are bad at small talk, you notice every stumble and discount every good conversation. This is not proof you are wrong; it is a reminder that evidence is easy to collect in only one direction.

Separating observable facts from assumptions

A simple tool does much of the heavy lifting in this module: sort what you are telling yourself into two columns. Facts are things a neutral camera could record: “My manager replied with one word.” Assumptions are interpretations: “She’s irritated with me.”

Assumptions are not always wrong, and the goal is not forced positivity. The goal is accuracy. Once separated, you can ask: What else could be true? What evidence supports this? What evidence doesn’t? What would I do if I treated this as a question instead of a conclusion?

Balanced, compassionate reflection

The alternative to harsh self-talk is not blind cheerfulness. It is balanced, specific, and kind. A balanced statement acknowledges what is real, including mistakes, without turning it into a character judgment: “That meeting didn’t go as planned. I was underprepared on the budget. I can prepare differently next time.”

A helpful test: would this sentence still be true and useful if I said it to someone I respect? If it would sound cruel or inaccurate coming from a friend, it probably isn’t the most reliable account of what happened.

Scenario: The one-word reply

Priya shares a draft with her manager and receives a one-word reply: “Noted.” Her narrator immediately supplies a story: “She hated it. She’s losing confidence in me. I should have asked for feedback sooner.” By lunch Priya is rewriting the draft from scratch.

Sorting the facts: the manager wrote “Noted.” and has back-to-back meetings on Thursdays. Everything else is assumption. Other possibilities that fit the facts include that the manager is busy, the draft is fine, or she plans to review it later. None are guaranteed, but all are plausible.

Priya’s balanced response: “I don’t know what ‘Noted’ means yet. I can ask for specific feedback on Friday, and until then I’ll keep working on what I planned.” Notice that she did not pretend to feel certain — she simply stopped treating a guess as a fact.

Guided reflection

Take your time. Short, honest answers are enough. Skip anything that feels like too much today.

1. What are the three most common sentences your inner narrator says when you make a mistake?

2. Which of these use absolutes, labels, mind-reading, or certain predictions? Mark the pattern for each.

3. Pick one limiting belief you hold. What real experiences did it come from, and what has it quietly kept you from trying?

4. What evidence exists that this belief is not completely true? List anything, however small.

5. What would a wise, kind friend say about the same situation?

Worksheet

Worksheet: Inner-Critic Reflection

Use a recent situation where your inner critic was loud. Work through each step in order. Write in full sentences if you can; it slows your thinking down in a useful way.

Completed example (fictional): Priya's Inner-Critic Reflection

1. SITUATION

I sent a draft to my manager. The reply was one word: "Noted."

2. THE CRITIC'S WORDS

"She hated it. She's losing confidence in me. I should have asked for feedback sooner."

3. FACTS

The reply said "Noted." Thursdays are back-to-back meetings for her.

4. ASSUMPTIONS

That she hated it, that she's losing confidence, that I should have asked sooner.

5. OTHER EXPLANATIONS

She's busy. The draft is fine. She plans to review it later.

6. WHAT I'D SAY TO SOMEONE I RESPECT

"One word from a busy person isn't a verdict. Ask for specifics."

7. BALANCED STATEMENT

I don't know what "Noted" means yet. I can ask for specific feedback on Friday.

8. PRACTICAL NEXT STEP

Keep working on what I planned, and send a short feedback request on Friday.

Fictional example for illustration. Your own answers can be shorter, messier, and entirely different.

1. Situation — what happened, in camera-fact terms only:

2. The critic’s words — write exactly what your inner voice said:

3. Facts — which parts of the above could a neutral observer confirm?

4. Assumptions — which parts are interpretation, prediction, or mind-reading?

5. Other explanations — list at least two alternatives that also fit the facts:

6. What would I say to someone I respect in this exact situation?

7. A balanced statement — honest about what went wrong, specific, and not a verdict on my character:

8. One practical next step that follows from the balanced statement:

Real-world action: Catch and rewrite

Three times this week, write down a harsh thing your inner voice says in the moment (a phone note is fine). Within a day, reread it, sort facts from assumptions, and write a balanced version underneath. You are training a skill, so do it even when the thought seems minor.

What I did, what happened, what I noticed:

Module recap

- An inner narrator is normal; what matters is its tone and how much authority you give it.
- Harsh self-talk often uses absolutes, labels, mind-reading, and certain predictions.
- Limiting beliefs are conclusions that stopped being questioned.
- Separate what a neutral camera could record from what you are assuming.
- Balanced reflection is honest and specific, not forced positivity.

Completion record

My key insight from this module:

Date completed: ___ / ___ / _____

MODULE 4 OF 6 · ABOUT 55 MINUTES

Break People-Pleasing Patterns

Understand the fear behind “yes,” and begin to choose it on purpose.

Lesson

What people-pleasing really is

People-pleasing is not the same as being kind. Kindness comes from care and leaves you with a choice. People-pleasing is driven by anxiety about how others will react, and it often leaves you resentful, exhausted, or unsure what you want.

A simple way to tell them apart is to check how it feels afterwards. Genuine generosity usually leaves you feeling fine, even if it cost you something. People-pleasing tends to leave a residue: tension before you agreed, resentment afterwards, or relief that it is over rather than satisfaction that you helped.

The fear underneath

Beneath most people-pleasing sits a prediction: “If I say no, disappoint them, or disagree, something bad will happen. They’ll be angry, leave, think less of me, or stop needing me.” Sometimes this prediction was accurate in childhood or in a past relationship. Sometimes it is simply never tested.

Because the fear is rarely examined, the behavior continues. Each time you give in, you avoid the feared outcome, and your brain learns that giving in is what keeps you safe. The cycle strengthens even though the cost to you grows.

Overcommitting and ignoring your own needs

A common sign of the pattern is a schedule that reflects everyone’s priorities but yours. You say yes before checking your calendar, agree to “quick favors” that are never quick, and leave no space for rest or for projects of your own.

Another sign is losing track of your preferences. When you spend years anticipating what others want, the question “What do I want?” can produce a blank. If this is you, that blank is not a defect. It is the predictable result of long practice at looking outward, and it can be rebuilt.

The hidden costs

People-pleasing can look like a low-risk strategy, but it carries real costs: resentment that leaks out sideways, relationships built on a version of you that is not quite accurate, time and energy depleted, and a growing sense that nobody knows the real you.

It can also quietly mislead others. When you always say yes, people cannot tell when something is difficult for you, which means they cannot adjust. Honest limits are often a kindness to everyone involved.

Mapping before changing

Change starts with accurate mapping. You will build a personal people-pleasing map covering where it happens, with whom, what you fear, what you typically do, and what it costs. Patterns are usually context-specific: someone may be assertive at work and agreeable with family, or the reverse.

Resist the urge to fix everything at once. Choose one low-stakes situation to practice first. Small experiments gather real evidence about whether your feared outcome actually happens.

Scenario: The “quick favor”

Sam is finishing a deadline when a colleague asks, “Can you take a quick look at my slides tonight?” Sam’s chest tightens. He knows the evening is already full. He hears himself say, “Sure, no problem!”

Mapping it: Trigger — a direct request from someone at work. Fear — “They’ll think I’m not a team player.” Behavior — immediate yes. Cost — a late evening, resentment, and a pile of his own unfinished work.

A different response is possible without being unkind: “I’d like to help, but tonight is packed. I could look tomorrow at 10 for twenty minutes, or send a few quick tips now.” Sam is still helpful. He has simply included himself in the equation.

Guided reflection

Take your time. Short, honest answers are enough. Skip anything that feels like too much today.

1. In which relationships or settings do you find it hardest to say no? What do they have in common?

2. Finish the sentence: “If I disappointed them, I’m afraid that _____.” Is this prediction certain, or a guess?

3. Describe a time you said yes when you meant no. How did you feel before, during, and afterwards?

4. What have you stopped doing, wanting, or noticing because you were busy managing other people’s needs?

5. Think of a moment when a limit you set was respected. What did that show you?

Worksheet

Worksheet: People-Pleasing Audit and Pattern Map

Part A is a quick audit. Part B builds your personal map. Be honest and specific; nobody needs to see this but you.

Part A — How true is each statement for you? (1 = never, 5 = very often)

I say yes before checking whether I have the time or energy.

1 2 3 4 5

I feel guilty or anxious when I decline a request.

1 2 3 4 5

I change my opinion to avoid disagreement.

1 2 3 4 5

I feel responsible for other people's moods.

1 2 3 4 5

I find it hard to ask for help or state a need directly.

1 2 3 4 5

I feel resentful after helping, but I do not say so.

1 2 3 4 5

I struggle to know what I want when others are involved.

1 2 3 4 5

Person / setting	What they ask or expect	What I fear if I say no	What I usually do	What it costs me

Which row is the most draining? Why?

Choose one low-stakes situation for a practice experiment. What will you do differently?

What do you predict will happen? (Record this so you can compare it with what actually happens.)

Real-world action: The pause

Practice one small delay this week: when someone asks for something, say “Let me check and get back to you.” Then take at least an hour to decide. Afterwards, record what you chose and how it felt. The pause alone often changes the answer.

What I did, what happened, what I noticed:

Module recap

- People-pleasing is driven by fear of reactions; kindness leaves you with a choice.
- Underneath is usually an unexamined prediction about what happens if you disappoint someone.
- Overcommitting and losing touch with your own preferences are common signs.
- Resentment and inaccurate relationships are hidden costs of constant agreement.
- Map the pattern first, then run small, low-stakes experiments.

Completion record

My key insight from this module:

Date completed: ___ / ___ / _____

MODULE 5 OF 6 · ABOUT 60 MINUTES

Build Healthy Boundaries

Turn your needs and limits into clear, kind, usable words.

Lesson

What a boundary is (and isn't)

A boundary is a statement about what you will do or what you are available for, not an attempt to control someone else. "I'm not available to take calls after 8 p.m." is a boundary. "You must stop calling me late" is a demand. The difference matters because you can only reliably control your own actions.

Boundaries are not punishments or walls. At their best they are information that lets other people understand how to be in a relationship with you.

Start with needs, limits, and values

Before you can state a boundary you need to know what it protects. Three questions help: What do I need to feel steady (sleep, quiet time, honest communication)? Where is my limit (the point past which I feel resentful or unsafe)? What do I value that this boundary would honor (rest, honesty, family, work I am proud of)?

A useful signal is resentment. Resentment often means a limit has already been crossed, and you did not say so. Use it as a clue rather than as a verdict on the other person.

Saying no without a speech

Many people believe that a no requires an elaborate justification. Over-explaining invites negotiation, because each reason is something the other person can solve. You are allowed to give a brief reason or no reason at all.

A well-formed boundary tends to have four parts: acknowledge the person or request, state your limit, offer an alternative if you genuinely want to, and stop. "Thanks for asking. I can't take that on this week. I can help the following week if that works."

Tone, timing, and delivery

You do not have to be harsh to be clear. Warm, calm, and brief usually work best. Choose a moment when both of you can listen, not in the middle of a conflict. Written messages are fine for many boundaries, particularly where you tend to back down in conversation.

Expect some discomfort. A boundary may disappoint someone, and feeling uneasy afterwards does not mean you did something wrong. It often means you are doing something unfamiliar.

When people push back

Some people will respect a boundary immediately, some will test it, and some will object. You can repeat your statement calmly rather than re-arguing it: “I understand it’s inconvenient. My answer is still no.” Consistency matters more than eloquence.

If someone repeatedly disregards a reasonable boundary, you are allowed to adjust how much access, time, or energy you give. In situations involving abuse, threats, or safety concerns, reach out to a qualified professional or support service; this academy cannot provide safety planning.

Scenario: The weekend message

Leila’s manager often sends requests on Saturday evenings and Leila, who dislikes conflict, usually responds within the hour. She is beginning to dread weekends.

Her needs: uninterrupted time off. Her limit: she resents replying outside work hours. Her value: being reliable and being rested. Instead of stopping replies abruptly, she says on Monday: “I want to do my best work, and I recharge on weekends. I’ll reply to non-urgent messages first thing on Monday. If something is genuinely urgent, call me.”

Her manager may adjust easily or may test it. Either way, Leila has given clear, kind information and kept the decision about her own time in her own hands.

Guided reflection

Take your time. Short, honest answers are enough. Skip anything that feels like too much today.

1. Where do you feel resentful or drained right now? Which limit might be hiding underneath?

2. What do you most need in order to feel steady during an ordinary week?

3. Which value would a new boundary protect, and how would that change how you feel about stating it?

4. What do you worry will happen if you state this boundary? What is the most realistic outcome?

5. Which kind of response would be hardest for you to hold your ground against — anger, guilt, silence, or persuasion?

Worksheet

Worksheet: Needs, Limits & Boundary Script Builder

Part A clarifies your needs and limits. Part B turns one of them into a ready-to-use script. A full Boundary Scripts Library is included in your resources.

Completed example (fictional): Leila's Boundary Script

NEEDS / LIMIT / VALUE

Need: uninterrupted time off. Limit: I resent replying outside work hours. Value: being reliable and rested.

CONTEXT

Work. My manager often sends requests on Saturday evenings.

1. ACKNOWLEDGE

"I want to do my best work for you."

2. STATE THE LIMIT

"I recharge on weekends, so I'll reply to non-urgent messages first thing on Monday."

3. OFFER AN ALTERNATIVE

"If something is genuinely urgent, please call me."

4. IF THEY PUSH BACK

"I understand it's inconvenient. My plan is still to reply on Monday."

Fictional example for illustration. Your own answers can be shorter, messier, and entirely different.

Part A — My top three needs right now (e.g. rest, quiet, honesty, predictability):

Situations where I reach my limit (what is happening, with whom):

Values these boundaries would protect:

Part B — Context for my script (work, family, friendship, or romantic relationship; the specific situation):

1. Acknowledge (recognize the person or request):

2. State the limit (brief, in ‘I’ language):

3. Offer an alternative (optional — only if you truly want to):

4. If they push back, my calm repeat is:

Put it together — my full script, in words I would actually say:

Boundary script examples

Adapt the wording to sound like you. The full library is in Resources.

WORK

Declining extra work

“Thanks for thinking of me. I’m at capacity this week, so I can’t take this on and do it well. If it can wait until [date], I’d be glad to look then.”

Messages outside working hours

“I’ll reply to non-urgent messages during working hours so I can give them proper attention. If something is truly urgent, please call.”

Pushing back on an unrealistic deadline

“I want to deliver this well. With the current scope, [date] isn’t realistic. I can deliver [part] by [date] or the full version by [date]. Which works better?”

Being interrupted or talked over

“I’d like to finish my point, and then I’d be glad to hear your thoughts.”

FAMILY

Declining a visit or event

“I love you and I’m not able to make it this time. I’d like to catch up another day. Would [day] work?”

Unsolicited advice

“I appreciate that you care. I’m working through this myself, and what would help most right now is just listening.”

Topics you don’t want to discuss

“I’m not going to talk about that. Tell me about [something else] instead.”

Lending money or being relied on repeatedly

“I can’t help financially this time. I care about you and I’m happy to help you think through other options.”

FRIENDSHIP

Declining plans

“Thanks for the invite. I need a quiet night this week. Could we plan for [day] instead?”

A friend who always vents

“I care about what you’re going through. I don’t have the capacity to talk through it tonight. Can we talk tomorrow?”

Cancelling at the last minute (you)

“I’m sorry for the short notice. I’m not up to it tonight, and I’d rather be honest than push through. Can we reschedule?”

Feeling consistently one-sided

“I’ve noticed I’m usually the one reaching out. I’d like our friendship to feel mutual. Can we talk about it?”

RELATIONSHIPS

Needing alone time

“I love spending time with you, and I need some time alone to recharge. I’ll be glad to reconnect afterwards.”

Raising a recurring issue

“When [specific thing] happens, I feel [feeling]. What I need is [request]. Would you be open to that?”

Disagreeing calmly

“I see it differently, and I’d like to understand your view. I’d also like to share mine.”

Pausing a heated conversation

“I want to talk about this and I’m too upset to do it well. Can we take twenty minutes and come back?”

Real-world action: One boundary, one week

Choose one low-to-medium stakes boundary from your script and communicate it this week, in person or in writing. Afterwards, record what you said, how the other person responded, and what you learned. If the situation involves safety concerns, consult a qualified professional first.

What I did, what happened, what I noticed:

Module recap

- A boundary describes what you will do; it does not control other people.
- Know your needs, limits, and values before you write the words.

- Acknowledge, state the limit, offer an alternative if you want, and stop.
- Warm, brief, and consistent beats long and defensive.
- Discomfort after a boundary is common and does not mean you were wrong.

Completion record

My key insight from this module:

Date completed: ___ / ___ / _____

MODULE 6 OF 6 · ABOUT 50 MINUTES

Integrate Your New Choices

Turn insight into a small, sustainable plan you can actually keep.

Lesson

Insight is not the same as change

Understanding a pattern is valuable, but understanding alone rarely changes behavior. Change shows up in small repeated choices, made in ordinary moments, usually when you are tired or under pressure. This final module turns your insights into a plan that survives real life.

Self-trust is built the same way trust is built with anyone: by keeping small promises. When you say you will pause before agreeing and you do, you add evidence that your word to yourself counts.

Review what you've learned

Begin by looking back through your earlier worksheets. Read your pattern map, your values, your inner-critic notes, your people-pleasing map, and your boundary script. You are looking for threads that recur: a particular trigger, a repeated story, a situation where you tend to abandon yourself.

The goal is not a perfect summary. It is a short list of recognizable themes, written in words that feel true to you. Two or three are plenty.

Choose small and specific

Big resolutions fail because they require willpower at the exact moments willpower is lowest. Smaller actions work better: specific, tied to a situation, and easy enough to do on a bad day. "Be more assertive" is a hope. "When someone asks for a favor, I say 'Let me check and get back to you'" is an action.

A useful format is the if–then plan: "If [situation], then I will [specific action]." It reduces the decisions you have to make in the moment and makes the action easier to start.

Expect setbacks and plan for them

You will slip. You will say yes when you meant no, or catch yourself in a long internal criticism. A setback is not evidence the work failed; it is information about which situations are hardest. A good plan includes a recovery step: “If I slip, I will write down what happened, without judgment, and choose one thing to try next time.”

Pay attention to the thing you say to yourself after a slip. That response matters more than the slip itself.

A progress-review routine

A weekly review of ten to fifteen minutes keeps the plan alive. Look at what you tried, what happened, what you learned, and what you will adjust. Include one thing you handled well, because we tend to remember only what went wrong.

Every month, step back further: Which patterns appear less often? Which situations remain hard? Do your actions still match your values? Adjust the plan accordingly. This is a practice you can return to for as long as it is useful.

Scenario: Building a plan that holds

After finishing five modules, Ana notices three themes: she assumes silence means disapproval, she says yes before thinking, and she over-prepares to avoid criticism. Her first plan was ambitious: “Stop caring what people think.” It lasted four days.

She rewrites it in small, specific steps. If someone doesn’t reply within a day, then she waits until the next business day before following up. If someone asks for a favor, then she says “Let me check and get back to you.” If she catches harsh self-talk, then she writes one balanced sentence.

On Sundays she spends ten minutes on a review. Some weeks she follows through on two of three; she records that honestly and moves on. After two months, she notices the pauses feel easier and she has said a calm no several times.

Guided reflection

Take your time. Short, honest answers are enough. Skip anything that feels like too much today.

1. Looking back over all five modules, what are the two or three themes that keep appearing?

2. What has surprised you most about your own patterns?

3. Which situation is most likely to pull you back into an old pattern? What makes it difficult?

4. What do you want your relationship with yourself to feel like six months from now?

5. How will you speak to yourself when you slip up?

Worksheet

Worksheet: Personal Self-Trust Action Plan

This is the plan you will keep using after the academy. Keep it short enough to fit on one page.

My key insights (2–3 recurring themes):

The values I want my choices to reflect:

If–then plan 1 — If (situation) ... then I will (specific action):

If–then plan 2:

If–then plan 3:

One boundary I am working on, and when I will communicate it:

Who or what can support me (people, routines, professionals):

When I slip, I will:

My weekly review: day and time, and the three questions I will ask:

A promise to myself, in my own words:

Real-world action: Start the weekly review

Put your first 15-minute review in your calendar now, then use the Weekly Reflection & Progress Tracker in your resource library. Complete it for four consecutive weeks. After the fourth week, adjust your action plan based on what you've learned.

What I did, what happened, what I noticed:

Module recap

- Change comes from small repeated choices, not from insight alone.
- Review your worksheets and pick two or three recurring themes.
- Use specific if–then plans that are easy to start on a hard day.
- Plan for slips, and pay attention to how you speak to yourself afterwards.
- A short weekly review and a monthly check-in keep the plan alive.

Completion record

My key insight from this module:

Date completed: ___ / ___ / _____

Self-Worth Reflection Exercises

Eight short exercises to return to whenever your sense of worth gets tied to performance or approval.

1. The Condition Check: Finish the sentence “I feel worthwhile when _____” five different ways. Which ones are conditions you could loosen?

2. Evidence File: List ten things you did in the past year that reflect your values, regardless of the outcome.

3. The Friend Test: Write what you would say to a friend in your exact situation, then address it to yourself.

4. Comparison as Information: Name someone you compare yourself to. What quality are you drawn to? What is one small way to practice it?

5. Receiving Well: Next time you are complimented, say only “Thank you.” Afterwards, note what the urge to deflect felt like.

6. Own Read First: Before asking for reassurance, write what you already believe about the situation.

7. Rest Without Earning It: Schedule 30 minutes of rest that must not be productive. Record what comes up.

8. Good-Enough Standard: For one task this week, decide ahead of time what “good enough” looks like and stop there.

Trigger & Pattern Tracker

Log triggers as they happen to see your recurring patterns clearly.

Date	Trigger	Feeling & body sensation	What I did	Story I told myself	Intensity (0–10)	Possible need underneath

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Boundary-Setting Scripts Library

Sixteen ready-to-adapt scripts for work, family, friendships, and relationships, plus a space to write your own.

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My own scripts

Situation and script 1:

Situation and script 2:

Situation and script 3:

Personal Values & Needs Worksheet

Choose your core values, identify your needs, and connect both to specific daily choices.

Part A — Circle (tick) the values that feel most like you, then narrow to your top three below.

- [ ] Honesty
- [ ] Kindness
- [ ] Courage
- [ ] Growth
- [ ] Curiosity
- [ ] Calm
- [ ] Family
- [ ] Friendship
- [ ] Independence
- [ ] Creativity
- [ ] Health
- [ ] Reliability
- [ ] Fairness
- [ ] Freedom
- [ ] Learning
- [ ] Respect
- [ ] Faith / meaning
- [ ] Adventure
- [ ] Craftsmanship

- [ ] Generosity
- [ ] Security
- [ ] Balance

My top three values and what each means to me in practice:

Part B — Which needs matter most to you right now?

- [ ] Rest
- [ ] Quiet / alone time
- [ ] Honest communication
- [ ] Predictability
- [ ] Connection
- [ ] Autonomy
- [ ] Appreciation
- [ ] Play / fun
- [ ] Movement
- [ ] Creative expression
- [ ] Support
- [ ] Clear expectations
- [ ] Financial stability
- [ ] Meaning / purpose

Which of these values or needs is least honored in my current week?

One small, specific change that would honor it:

Weekly Reflection & Progress Tracker

A twelve-week tracker for your weekly ten-to-fifteen-minute review.

Week 1

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

- [ ] Review completed

Week 2

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 3

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 4

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 5

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 6

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 7

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 8

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 9

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 10

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 11

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

☐ Review completed

Week 12

One thing I handled well

What I tried this week (pause, boundary, balanced thought...)

A moment that was hard, and what I noticed

What I learned about my pattern

One adjustment for next week

- [ ] Review completed

The Shadow Work Academy is an educational self-reflection program and is not therapy, diagnosis, or medical advice. Personal use only; please do not share or resell.